

In Loving Memory of

Eleanor Mae Whitfield

March 14, 1941 — September 21, 2025

*“To live in hearts we leave behind
is not to die.”*

— Thomas Campbell

Celebration of Life

Saturday, October 4, 2025 · 11:00 AM

Grace Chapel · 412 Linden Avenue · Maplewood

Order of Service

Prelude

“Clair de Lune” — performed by the Grace Chapel Quartet

Processional

Officiant and Family

Opening Prayer

Reverend Daniel Okafor

Hymn

“Amazing Grace” — Congregation

Scripture Reading

Psalm 23 — read by Marcus Whitfield, son

Remembrances

Family and Friends

Musical Tribute

“What a Wonderful World” — Ada Whitfield, granddaughter

Eulogy

Delivered by Claire Whitfield-Reyes, daughter

Hymn

“It Is Well with My Soul” — Congregation

Words of Comfort

Reverend Daniel Okafor

Benediction and Recessional

“Ode to Joy”

Interment to follow at Maplewood Memorial Gardens.

A Life Remembered

Eleanor Mae Whitfield was born on March 14, 1941, in Savannah, Georgia, the second of four children of Harold and Ruth Caldwell. From her earliest days she was known for a quick laugh, an unshakable sense of fairness, and a gift for making every guest at her table feel like family.

Eleanor graduated from Spelman College in 1963 with a degree in education, and for thirty-four years she taught English literature at Maplewood High School, where generations of students remember her habit of reciting poetry from memory and her insistence that every voice in the classroom mattered. She was named Teacher of the Year three times, an honor she accepted each time, in her words, “on behalf of the semicolon.”

In 1965 she married the love of her life, James Whitfield, a union of sixty years marked by Sunday drives, crossword puzzles done in ink, and a garden that was the envy of Linden Avenue. Together they raised two children, Claire and Marcus, and delighted in five grandchildren and two great-grandchildren.

Eleanor was a devoted member of Grace Chapel, where she sang alto in the choir for four decades and organized the annual harvest food drive. She loved peach cobbler, Ella Fitzgerald records, long letters written by hand, and the first cool morning of autumn.

She is survived by her husband James; her children Claire Whitfield-Reyes (Antonio) and Marcus Whitfield (Dana); grandchildren Ada, Simone, Elijah, Rosa, and June; great-grandchildren Theo and Maya; and her sister, Lillian Caldwell Brooks. She was preceded in death by her parents and her brothers, Harold Jr. and Thomas.

Hymns & Readings

Amazing Grace

Amazing grace! How sweet the sound
That saved a wretch like me!
I once was lost, but now am found;
Was blind, but now I see.

'Twas grace that taught my heart to fear,
And grace my fears relieved;
How precious did that grace appear
The hour I first believed.

Psalm 23

The Lord is my shepherd; I shall not want.
He maketh me to lie down in green pastures:
he leadeth me beside the still waters.
He restoreth my soul.

Yea, though I walk through the valley of the shadow of death,
I will fear no evil: for thou art with me;
thy rod and thy staff they comfort me.
Surely goodness and mercy shall follow me all the days of my life:
and I will dwell in the house of the Lord for ever.

It Is Well with My Soul

When peace like a river attendeth my way,
When sorrows like sea billows roll;
Whatever my lot, Thou hast taught me to say,
It is well, it is well with my soul.

It is well with my soul,
It is well, it is well with my soul.

Remembering Grandma Ellie

“She kept a tin of butter cookies on the second shelf, and a poem for every occasion. She taught us that kindness is a habit, not a mood — and that no one leaves her kitchen hungry.”

— The grandchildren

Acknowledgements

The family of Eleanor Mae Whitfield wishes to express heartfelt gratitude for the outpouring of love, prayers, phone calls, flowers, and every act of kindness shown during this time of loss. Your compassion has been a source of great comfort.

Special thanks to the congregation of Grace Chapel, the Maplewood High School alumni community, and the caring staff of Riverside Hospice for their gentle devotion in Eleanor's final months.

Pallbearers

Marcus Whitfield · Antonio Reyes · Elijah Whitfield
David Brooks · Samuel Okafor · Gerald Mason

Repast

Immediately following the interment,
the family invites you to the Grace Chapel Fellowship Hall
for a meal and the sharing of memories.

In Lieu of Flowers

Donations may be made to the
Eleanor M. Whitfield Scholarship for Future Teachers
c/o Maplewood High School.

*“And now these three remain:
faith, hope and love.
But the greatest of these is love.”*

— 1 Corinthians 13:13



Services entrusted to
Harmony Rest Funeral Home
88 Willow Lane, Maplewood · (555) 014-2210